



BEFORE

During 1862, a series of Union successes on land in Tennessee and by river flotillas on the Mississippi cleared most of the Confederate positions along the river.

NORTH AND SOUTH

The capture of [New Orleans](#) opened the Mississippi to Union warships coming up from the south. Union river forces also gained the upper hand in actions on the Ohio and attacked south from Missouri on the Mississippi itself. After defeating Southern vessels near Memphis in June 1862, they reached the Yazoo River above Vicksburg and were joined there by some of Farragut's force from New Orleans (see [Memphis falls](#)).

GRANT'S FIRST VICTORIES

In the spring of 1862, General Grant fought the successful [Henry and Donelson campaign](#) in northern Tennessee, then narrowly avoided defeat at [Shiloh](#). By fall 1862, further victories had confirmed the Union hold on Memphis and Corinth.

After consolidating his army at Memphis, Tennessee, in the fall of 1862, Grant decided on a two-pronged offensive downriver against the Confederate Mississippi bastion at Vicksburg.

A swift descent by 40,000 men of General William Tecumseh Sherman's wing of the army along the Mississippi would be followed by Grant himself taking an overland route. But Confederate cavalry raids by Earl Van Dorn and Nathan Bedford Forrest so badly disrupted Grant's logistical and supply lines that the Union commander was compelled to call off his advance.

The telegram informing Sherman of this change never reached him, and so the Confederates at Vicksburg, under the command of General John C. Pemberton, mobilized to meet Sherman head-on. At Chickasaw Bayou on December 29, Sherman launched 20,000 of his troops against the steep bluffs and suffered 1,800 casualties to the Confederates' 200. Grant would never again attack from the north. He now considered the problem.

The terrain north and west of the city presented numerous obstacles to an army on the march. It was swampy, forested, streaked by bayous and streams, and offered very few usable roads. Vicksburg itself was defended by well-placed heavy cannon that could devastate any Union fleet floating downstream. Four times Grant tried to bypass the city to the west by cutting canals and using